B2B PRODUCT STRATEGY | 2 TO 3 YEARS

# From AI that answers to AI that finishes the job

A strategy for an AI customer operations platform serving mid-market e-commerce brands, benchmarked against Zendesk.

**5.3x**

monthly savings over platform cost for every 10,000 post-purchase tickets, at a 25% automation rate

$20,025 saved vs $3,750 paid. Inputs and sources on slide 4.

**Saadurya K V**

# Strategy on a page: resolve the issue, do not just reply

| | |
|---|---|
| **Vision** | A customer issue is finished when the system of record confirms it, not when the chat ends. |
| **Mission** | Resolve post-purchase issues end to end, safely, for mid-market e-commerce brands that ship physical goods. |
| **Strategy** | Wedge: read-only order and delivery resolution on top of the helpdesk they already run. Moat: verified-outcome log, action-safety layer, order and carrier connectors. Trade-off: no logistics, no helpdesk replacement, no enterprise. Metric: verified outcomes per account per week. Guardrail: no more than 0.5% of automated actions reversed. |
| **Roadmap** | Year 1: order and delivery. Year 2: returns, exchanges and refunds with approvals. Year 3: connected workflows across Support, Operations and Finance. |

# Start with mid-market e-commerce brands, a type of company and not one account

## Startups

Too early

My four founder interviews had support teams of 1, 1, 2 and 4 people, run through direct contact, a bot or Slack. Support is a person, not a function, so a platform adds process they do not need.

## Mid-market

Start here

200 to 1,000 staff. Already runs a helpdesk with manual ticket assignment, and ticket volume is high enough for cost per ticket to show in a budget review. Gap to test: whether they also lack a team to build AI actions themselves.

## Enterprise

Later

Zendesk Enterprise has no public price and Agentforce adds $125 per user per month. Sold through sales teams, against the strongest incumbents.

### THE SEGMENT, DEFINED SO ANY MATCHING BRAND QUALIFIES

1. 200 to 1,000 employees, checked at lead stage.
2. Ships physical goods and handles returns as routine (apparel, beauty, footwear, home).
3. Already runs a helpdesk (Zendesk, Freshdesk or similar) and an order system.
4. At least 5,000 post-purchase tickets a month (my screening threshold, to calibrate).
5. Delays mostly come from missing information, not carrier failure (slide 5).

### WHY ANY SIMILAR BRAND WANTS THE SAME THING

They share one journey: order, delivery, return, refund, and the same three systems behind it: store, carrier and payments. The ticket mix repeats across them: order status, returns, refunds.

### EVIDENCE GAP

My interviewees were 4 founders under 200 staff. Mid-market buyers are the next 10 interviews.

# Every order creates tickets, and each human contact costs about $8

### HOW OFTEN

Daily: 200 to 500 tickets per 1,000 orders.

Order status alone is up to 30% of tickets (survey of 12,000 stores).

19.3% of online sales are returned (NRF 2025).

### HOW PAINFUL

$8.01 per live-channel contact vs $0.10 self-service (Gartner, 2019, US).

About 9% of returns are fraudulent (NRF), so a wrong automatic refund has a price.

### WHY THEY PAY: THE INEQUALITY WITH REAL INPUTS, PER 10,000 TICKETS A MONTH

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Platform cost** | 2,500 verified outcomes x $1.50 | **$3,750 / month** |
| **Savings** | 2,500 avoided contacts x $8.01 | **$20,025 / month** |
| **Net** | $20,025 minus $3,750 | **$16,275 / month** |

Inputs: 25% automation (under the 30% order-status ceiling), $1.50 per outcome (between Intercom at $0.99 and Zendesk at $2.00).

Break-even human cost is $1.50 a contact. At half Gartner's cost ($4.00) the net is still $6,250 a month.

Savings arrive as hiring avoided while orders grow, not as layoffs.

### HOW BIG

Top-down: AI for customer service grows from $12.06B (2024) to $47.82B (2030), 25.8% a year (MarketsandMarkets). Bottom-up: 1,000 accounts at Year-1 usage = $45M a year; at Year-2 usage (4,000 outcomes) = $72M, which is 0.15% of the 2030 market. **Not yet known: how many accounts fit the segment. That is the first sizing task.**

Sources: Gorgias via eightx (tickets per 1,000 orders, order-status share); NRF 2025 returns report; Gartner 2019 press release; MarketsandMarkets; vendor pricing pages checked 13 Oct 2026.

# Core problem: AI that answers but cannot safely act

PROBLEM STATEMENT

**Support teams currently hand every order action (refund, cancel, return pickup) to a person, because a wrong action costs more than a slow reply, which caps AI automation at questions that need no action and stalls adoption.**

H1

## Hard issues need actions, not answers

Returns, refunds and failed deliveries require status checks and system changes.

Status: from the brief, untested. Confirm in buyer interviews.

**Decision: this is the problem I solve.**

H2

## Another layer on an unchanged stack

Most firms keep a help center, manual assignment and their CRM or ticketing tool. A new inbox adds work.

Status: from the brief, untested.

**Decision: run inside the helpdesk they own, read-only first, so no new inbox.**

H3

## The real pain is logistics

If carriers fail, tickets are a symptom and leaders fix logistics first.

Status: plausible, and it changes the plan.

**Decision: a boundary, below.**

THE BOUNDARY FOR THE NEXT TWO YEARS

We read carrier status and raise carrier tickets. We do not run carrier selection, warehouses or reverse logistics: that is a different buyer, a different moat, and serving everyone weakens the product. Screen: if most order-status tickets trace to real carrier delays and not missing information, ROI is capped, so that account waits.

# Four rivals bill three different units, and none bills a verified outcome

| VENDOR | SEAT PRICE, PER AGENT PER MONTH | AI UNIT AND PRICE | WHAT IS BILLED |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Zendesk** | $19 / $55 / $115 (Support Team, Suite Team, Suite Professional, billed annually) | Automated resolution: $1.50 committed, $2.00 pay-as-you-go. 5 to 10 included per agent. | AI resolves a request without escalating to a human. |
| **Intercom** | $29 / $85 / $132 (Essential, Advanced, Expert) | Fin: from $0.99 per outcome. | Pricing page does not define an outcome. |
| **Freshdesk** | $19 / $55 / $89 (Growth, Pro, Enterprise) | Freddy AI Agent: per session. 500 included, then $49 per 100. | A session, which is not a resolution. |
| **Salesforce** | Agentforce add-on $125 per user; Agentforce 1 editions from $550 | $2 per conversation, or $0.10 per action (Flex Credits). | Closest to per-action, at enterprise price. |

**OUR UNIT**

A verified outcome: the change is confirmed in the order system (refund issued, pickup booked), not just a closed chat.

**WHY I BENCHMARK ZENDESK**

It sits in the mid-market helpdesk seat we plug into (100,000+ customers), already sells resolutions, and bought Ultimate in 2024 to link bots to order systems. It is the rival most able to close our gap.

Sources: vendor pricing pages (zendesk.com, intercom.com, freshworks.com, salesforce.com), checked 13 Oct 2026; TechTarget on Zendesk and Ultimate, 2024.

# The moat sits above the model, in outcomes, approvals and connectors

### 1 Outcome data

Each action is stored with the before and after system state, so we learn which fix works for which exception, per carrier, pin code and product type. Playbooks improve with every account.

### 2 Action-safety layer

Permission scopes, refund limits, approval routing, audit log and rollback. Finance signs off on the limits, so trust is earned in a way a new prompt cannot copy.

### 3 Connectors

Store, carrier, payment and helpdesk, each a maintained write path. Each live connector raises the cost of leaving.

### 4 Cross-team workflow

Ops reads exception reports and Finance approves refunds in our queue. Three teams depend on it, and the cost of switching becomes organisational.

#### WHAT ZENDESK WOULD HAVE TO REBUILD TO CATCH UP

Fact: Zendesk says its agents act across systems and it bought Ultimate to link bots to CRM and order systems. Connectors can be bought.

1. **Its definition of success.** Today a resolution means no escalation to a human. Moving to a confirmed system change means measuring results inside every customer's systems, and it would lower the resolutions it can count.
2. **Its pricing logic.** Seats cost $19 to $115 a month, and every automated resolution reduces the agents who need a seat. Reconciling the two is a business decision, not a feature.
3. **Its horizontal design.** It serves every industry. Return windows, fraud rules and carrier exception codes need an opinionated e-commerce playbook.

Items 1 to 3 are my inference, not Zendesk statements.

# Land with read-only order status, expand only when a number says trust is earned

## Land

Months 0 to 6

Order status and delivery exceptions, read-only.

**TEAM ENTERING: HEAD OF CX**

Unlock: 25% of eligible tickets automated and under 0.5% of actions reversed, for 8 straight weeks.

## Expand 1

Months 6 to 12

Low-risk changes: cancel before dispatch, change address, start a return.

**TEAM ENTERING: OPERATIONS**

Unlock: Operations opens the weekly carrier-exception report 4 weeks running.

## Expand 2

Year 2

Refunds and exchanges, approval-first.

**TEAM ENTERING: FINANCE**

Unlock: Finance sets an auto-refund limit and overrides fewer than 5% of approvals over 60 days.

## Expand 3

Year 3

Proactive outreach before the customer asks. Governance for IT.

**TEAM ENTERING: IT**

Unlock: SSO, audit export and scoped permissions requested by IT.

### WHAT LAND LEAVES BEHIND, WHICH MAKES EXPAND POSSIBLE

An intent map: the account's tickets tagged by cause.

Live order and carrier connectors.

A verified-outcome log: CFO-grade proof of savings.

Exception data by carrier and pin code, which Operations did not have.

### WHO IS WHO

Buyer: Head of CX. Champion: support operations lead.

IT security review at day 0, so it is not a late blocker.

Refunds need Finance. The approval queue is the hook.

# Where the capacity goes: 70-20-10, with a clear list of what we will not build

YEAR 1 CAPACITY

**70%**

### Core

Read-only order and delivery resolution, order, carrier and helpdesk connectors, the action-safety layer.

**20%**

### Expansion

Returns and exchange pilots with 2 design partners, approval-first.

**10%**

### Moonshot

Proactive delivery-exception outreach, tested on a small cohort.

Pilots that prove out move from the 20% into the core. Year 2 split is reset from results.

**Big bet**

**Order and delivery resolution on live connectors.**

High upside, high confidence: order status is up to 30% of tickets.

**Pilot**

**Refunds and returns with write access.**

High upside, lower confidence. About 9% of returns are fraudulent, so approvals come first.

**Optimise**

**Intent tuning, hand-off to humans, help-center answers.**

Reliable small gains.

**Avoid**

**Replacing the helpdesk, carrier or warehouse tools, enterprise custom builds, pricing below $0.99.**

Serves everyone, or starts a price war a funded rival can win.

# How I will know it is working, and what would change my mind

## Metrics

- North star: verified outcomes per account per week.
- Adoption funnel: connected, live on one flow within 14 days, 25% automated, second workflow live.
- Guardrails: under 0.5% of actions reversed; satisfaction on AI-resolved tickets within 3 points of human-resolved.
- Stop rule: if reversals exceed 0.5% for two weeks, hold the next expansion.

## Risks and tripwires

- Zendesk or Intercom bills on verified outcomes: sharpen the safety layer and vertical playbooks.
- Models and connectors become commodities, as with Jasper: the moat has to be the data and approvals.
- Scaling too early: a new connector ships only after one design partner runs on it.
- Fraudulent refunds: no auto-refund without a limit that Finance set.

## Next 90 days

- Interview 10 buyers across the segment: Heads of CX, Operations and Finance.
- Confirm: post-purchase share of tickets, real cost per contact, who approves refunds.
- Painted-door test: a pilot offer page, 'refunds approved in your Finance inbox'. Build only if buyer requests clear a bar set beforehand.
- Sign 3 design partners before building Expand 2.

Thresholds are my starting targets, to be calibrated with the first design partners.